

In Paris, two boxers, Nishant Dev (71kg; **below**) and Lovlina Borgohain (75kg; **left**), lost in the quarterfinals, just one step away from securing a medal, while four others, including World champion Nikhat Zareen (50kg; **right**), were ousted earlier.

Worlds bronze medallist Nishant, who had a favourable draw, lost to Mexico's Marco Verde 4-1 after winning the first round. Amid the Indian fans' outcry over the decision being unfair, it was clear that Nishant, a smart boxer with a lot of power, could not give his best against a rough opponent whom he had tamed in the 2021 World Championships.

Nishant neither delivered his power punches nor kept himself safe, especially in the third round. His dipping endurance level also contributed to his loss.

Lovlina, who had a back issue during the run-up to the event, gave a strong challenge to Li Qian, the Asian Games champion. She could have done better in terms of boxing from a long range and using her right hand more effectively.

Nikhat also lost to a stronger Chinese opponent, another Asian Games champion Wu Yu, in the pre-quarterfinals. A tougher draw, due to the lack of seeding, may have impacted Nikhat's energy level. Wu's better execution of her plans was another apparent reason for halting the Indian's progress.

Former world no.1 Amit Panghal could not handle Patrick Chinyemba's tactical boxing and clean punches in the last 16 stage. Panghal had overcome a tough challenge from the Zambian in the Commonwealth Games semifinals on his way to winning the gold. In Paris, Chinyemba boxed at a different level.

Preeti Pawar, who was hospitalised during the

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camp in Germany, recovered in time to give her best before being beaten 3-2 in a close contest against Colombia's Yeni Castaneda in the pre-quarterfinals.

Jaismine Lamboria (57kg) was outsmarted by Tokyo silver medallist Nesthy Petecio in the opening round and could not make much of an impact.

Former Commonwealth Games champion Akhil Kumar said there should be a thorough analysis of the boxers' performance. "The SAI and the Sports Ministry provided everything. We had 11 support staff for a team of six boxers.

There should be a proper review of what they did," said Akhil.

"Did the coaches tell our star boxers where they went wrong and where they should improve? Why didn't we see

power in the punches despite the presence of strength and conditioning personnel? I think we should stop relying on foreign coaches and start believing in our homegrown coaches," he added.

Without any prejudice, the BFI needs to take some hard measures as course correction so that Indian boxers achieve their potential at the biggest stage.

Even though the place of boxing in Los Angeles 2028 is still not confirmed, the preparation for it cannot be put on the back burner.

A training method that suits the Indian boxers' mentality and game, identification and grooming of talents for the future, and developing a sound domestic structure without any regional bias should be the priority areas going forward.

Akhil quoted the famous Hindi poet Neeraj, urging the boxers to get up and fight again for a brighter future: "*Kuch sapno ke mar jaane se jivan mara nahi karta hai* (Life does not end just because some dreams die)."



RITU RAJ KONWAR